



Modelling Financial Markets

Seminar 3: Factor Models and Asset Pricing — Hands-on



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Acronyms used in this material (1/2)

- ▣ AI: Artificial Intelligence
- ▣ BAB: Betting Against Beta
- ▣ BET: Bucharest Exchange Trading (index)
- ▣ BH: Benjamini–Hochberg (procedure)
- ▣ BVB: Bursa de Valori București (the Bucharest Stock Exchange)
- ▣ CAPM: Capital Asset Pricing Model
- ▣ CMA: Conservative Minus Aggressive (investment factor)
- ▣ CML: Capital Market Line
- ▣ ETF: Exchange-Traded Fund
- ▣ FDR: False Discovery Rate
- ▣ FF3: Fama–French three-factor model
- ▣ FF5: Fama–French five-factor model
- ▣ FM: Fama–MacBeth (regressions)
- ▣ FWER: Family-Wise Error Rate
- ▣ GLS: Generalised Least Squares
- ▣ GRS: Gibbons–Ross–Shanken (test)
- ▣ HAC: Heteroskedasticity and Autocorrelation Consistent (standard errors)
- ▣ HML: High Minus Low (value factor)
- ▣ KRS: Kan–Robotti–Shanken (standard errors)
- ▣ ML: Machine Learning
- ▣ MOM: MOMentum factor
- ▣ NW: Newey–West (standard errors)
- ▣ OLS: Ordinary Least Squares
- ▣ PC1: first Principal Component
- ▣ PC2: second Principal Component
- ▣ PC3: third Principal Component

Acronyms used in this material (2/2)

- ▣ **PCA: Principal Component Analysis**
- ▣ **RF: Risk-Free rate**
- ▣ **RMW: Robust Minus Weak (profitability factor)**
- ▣ **SMB: Small Minus Big (size factor)**
- ▣ **SML: Security Market Line**
- ▣ **US: United States**

Today's Question and Required Outputs

- Question of the seminar: **does beta price the cross section, and how sure can we be?**
- Route
 - ▶ A1, A3, A5 on paper: the CAPM from the tangency portfolio, the Vasicek beta as a posterior mean, four multiple-testing rules
 - ▶ B1: one beta with classical, HAC and bootstrap inference; B2: a joint test of the CAPM; B3: latent factors by PCA
 - ▶ C2: find the errors in an AI answer; B4 at home
- Required outputs (checklist on the last core slide): the A derivations, one table and one figure per B exercise, the corrected C2 code, one interpretation sentence per exercise
- Notebook for today: [open the seminar notebook in Colab](#); each task names its notebook section
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Exercise Map

Exercise	Question	Type	Model
A1	why does the tangency portfolio price every asset by beta?	Solved	–
A3	why is the Vasicek beta a posterior mean?	Solved	–
A5	how many of ten candidate factors are discoveries?	Solved	–
B1	what are XLK's beta and alpha, and how precise?	Solved	–
B2	do nine sector ETFs reject the CAPM?	Solved	A1, B1
B3	how many factors drive US sector returns?	Solved	–
C2	what is wrong in an AI momentum backtest?	Proposed	B1, lecture
B4	what are the betas of the BVB blue chips?	Proposed	B1, A3
Extension packs	A1 Extended, A2, A4, A6–A8, B5–B11, C1, C3 (optional, after the seminar)	both	named on each task

- **[Solved]:** full solution in the slides and in the notebook, a model to copy; **[Proposed]:** you solve it, the solution is discussed in class
- Part A: derivations on paper; Part B: estimation and inference on real data, each ending with an interpretation question; Part C: open questions and AI critique

Data Manifest

Series	Source, field	Frequency	Sample
9 sector ETFs (XLB, XLE, XLF, XLI, XLK, XLP, XLU, XLV, XLY)	<SYMBOL>.US, adjusted close	month-end	Jan 1999 – Jul 2026
11 sector ETFs (the 9 + XLRE, XLC), SPY	<SYMBOL>.US, adjusted close	daily	20 Jun 2018 – 18 Sep 2026
Mkt-RF, SMB, HML, RMW, CMA, MOM, RF	Kenneth French Data Library , percent	monthly, daily	Jul 1963 – Jul 2026
25 size × B/M portfolios	Kenneth French Data Library , value-weighted	monthly	Jul 1963 – Jul 2026
11 BVB blue chips, BET	<SYMBOL>.R0, adjusted close; BET, close	daily	6 Jan 2015 (or listing) – 18 Sep 2026

- Market files: data/market/<SYMBOL>.csv, columns date, open, high, low, close, adjusted_close, volume
- Joint analyses: join the *prices* on common days first, then take returns; monthly returns from month-end prices
- BVB blue chips: TLV, SNP, BRD, TGN, FP, SNG, H2O, SNN, EL, DIGI, TEL

Setup: From Prices to Excess Returns

```
# notebook section "Setup" defines
# prices(), factors(), monthly_excess()
ex, F = monthly_excess(['XLK.US',
                        'SPY.US'])
# month-end adjusted prices -> simple
# returns -> minus RF -> join factors
print(len(ex), ex.index[0].date(),
      ex.index[-1].date())
print(ex['XLK.US'].head(3))
print(F[['Mkt-RF', 'RF']].head(3))
```

- Expected: $T = 331$ months, 1999-01-31 to 2026-07-31
- If the count differs, check the field, the month-end rule and the division by 100

	Jan 1999	Feb 1999	Mar 1999
P_{t-1} , XLK	12.1103	14.0359	12.6439
P_t , XLK	14.0359	12.6439	13.5835
$R_t = P_t / P_{t-1} - 1$	15.90%	-9.92%	7.43%
RF (/100)	0.35%	0.35%	0.43%
$R_t^e = R_t - RF_t$	15.55%	-10.27%	7.00%
Mkt-RF	3.47%	-4.08%	3.48%

- Worked line: $14.0359 / 12.1103 - 1 = 15.90\%$; minus 0.35% gives 15.55%
- Adjusted prices include dividends; RF and Mkt-RF are already excess or rate series

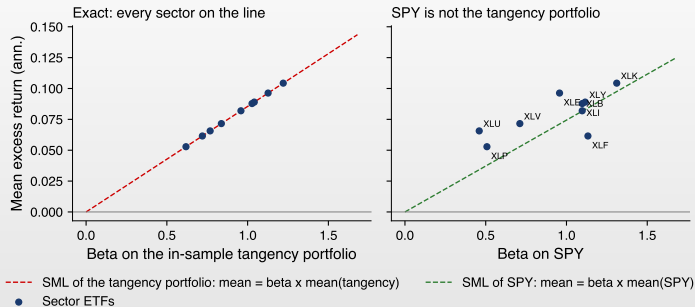
Notation Used in Every Exercise

- ▣ $R_{i,t}^e = R_{i,t} - R_{f,t}$: excess return of asset i in period t ; R_t^e : the $N \times 1$ vector of excess returns; f_t : a factor (Mkt-RF unless stated)
- ▣ Market model $R_{i,t}^e = \alpha_i + \beta_i f_t + \varepsilon_{i,t}$; $\hat{\alpha}, \hat{\beta}$: $N \times 1$; residual matrix $\hat{E}$: $T \times N$
- ▣ $\mu = \mathbb{E}[R_t^e]$, $\Sigma = \text{Cov}(R_t^e)$ ($N \times N$, positive definite); $SR = \mu/\sigma$ per period; annualise means $\times 12$, Sharpe ratios $\times \sqrt{12}$
- ▣ Maximum-likelihood (ML) moments divide by T : $\hat{\Sigma} = \hat{E}^\top \hat{E} / T$, $\hat{\sigma}_f^2 = \frac{1}{T} \sum_t (f_t - \bar{f})^2$
- ▣ Newey–West (HAC) errors: Bartlett weights $1 - l/(L+1)$, lag rule $L = \lfloor 4(T/100)^{2/9} \rfloor$ ($T = 331$: $L = 5$)
- ▣ Var_{cs} , Cov_{cs} : cross-sectional variance and covariance across the N assets

A1 [Solved]: The CAPM from the Tangency Portfolio — Task

- ▣ **Question:** if the market is the tangency portfolio, why must every asset satisfy $\mu_i = \beta_i \mu_m$?
- ▣ **Inputs:** N risky assets with expected excess returns $\boldsymbol{\mu}$ ($N \times 1$) and positive definite covariance $\boldsymbol{\Sigma}$; a risk-free asset
- ▣ **Assumption:** the market is the tangency portfolio $\mathbf{w}_m = \boldsymbol{\Sigma}^{-1} \boldsymbol{\mu} / c$, with the scalar $c = \mathbf{1}^\top \boldsymbol{\Sigma}^{-1} \boldsymbol{\mu} \neq 0$;
 $R_m^e = \mathbf{w}_m^\top \mathbf{R}^e$
- ▣ **Tasks**
 1. Express the covariance vector $\text{Cov}(\mathbf{R}^e, R_m^e) = \boldsymbol{\Sigma} \mathbf{w}_m$ as a function of $\boldsymbol{\mu}$ and c .
 2. Compute $\mu_m = \mathbf{w}_m^\top \boldsymbol{\mu}$ and $\sigma_m^2 = \mathbf{w}_m^\top \boldsymbol{\Sigma} \mathbf{w}_m$ and find the relation between them.
 3. Combine steps 1 and 2 to prove $\mu_i = \beta_i \mu_m$ for every asset, with $\beta_i = \text{Cov}(R_i^e, R_m^e) / \sigma_m^2$.
 4. Check the result on the 9 sector ETFs (monthly, 1999–2026): replace $\boldsymbol{\mu}$, $\boldsymbol{\Sigma}$ by sample moments and compare $\hat{\mu}_i$ with $\hat{\beta}_i \hat{\mu}_m$, first for the sample tangency portfolio, then for SPY.
- ▣ **Report:** the derivation in three steps, a chart of the two checks and one sentence
- ▣ Notebook: section A1

A1 [Solved]: Solution



1. $\Sigma w_m = \mu/c$, so $\text{Cov}(R^e, R_m^e) = \mu/c$
 2. $\sigma_m^2 = w_m^\top \Sigma w_m = \mu_m/c$, hence $c = \mu_m/\sigma_m^2$
 3. $\mu = c \text{ Cov}(R^e, R_m^e) = \beta \mu_m$: the SML
 4. Sample tangency portfolio (mean 8.55% a year): largest gap $\approx 3 \times 10^{-17}$; SPY: gaps up to 3.1% a year (XLU +3.1%, XLE +2.5%, XLF -2.3%)
- Any efficient portfolio prices exactly; a CAPM test asks whether the proxy is efficient

A3 [Solved]: Vasicek as a Posterior Mean — Task

- **Question:** why does the Vasicek rule shrink a noisy beta towards the cross-sectional mean?
- **Data:** 9 sector ETFs, monthly excess returns on SPY, January 1999 – December 2012; OLS betas with Newey–West errors
 - ▶ XLK: $\hat{\beta} = 1.415$, $\text{se} = 0.139$; cross-section: $\bar{\beta} = 0.949$, $\text{Var}_{cs}(\hat{\beta}) = 0.1159$, $\overline{\text{se}^2} = 0.0077$; XLK beta estimated on 2013–2026: 1.172
- **Assumptions:** prior $\beta_i \sim N(\bar{\beta}, \sigma_{\beta}^2)$; likelihood $\hat{\beta}_i | \beta_i \sim N(\beta_i, \text{se}_i^2)$ with se_i known
- **Tasks**
 1. Multiply prior and likelihood, complete the square in β and state the posterior distribution: its mean β_i^V and its variance.
 2. Use the law of total variance to show $\text{Var}_{cs}(\hat{\beta}) = \sigma_{\beta}^2 + \mathbb{E}[\text{se}^2]$, and write the empirical-Bayes estimator of σ_{β}^2 .
 3. Compute σ_{β}^2 , the weight w , β^V and the posterior standard deviation for XLK, and the Blume beta $0.33 + 0.67\hat{\beta}$.
 4. Compare the absolute errors of the raw, Vasicek and Blume betas against the later estimate 1.172.
- **Report:** the posterior, the numbers of step 3 and the three errors; Notebook: section A3

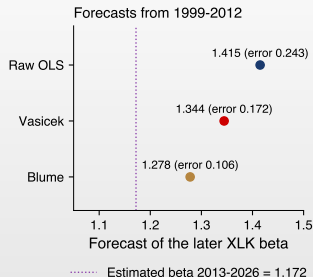
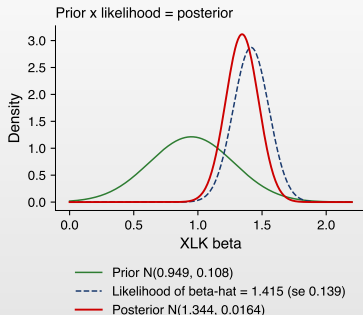
A3 [Solved]: Solution (1/2) — The Posterior

1. Posterior $\propto \exp\left\{-\frac{(\beta - \bar{\beta})^2}{2\sigma_{\beta}^2}\right\} \exp\left\{-\frac{(\hat{\beta} - \beta)^2}{2\text{se}^2}\right\}$; the exponent is

$$-\frac{1}{2} \left[\beta^2 \left(\frac{1}{\sigma_{\beta}^2} + \frac{1}{\text{se}^2} \right) - 2\beta \left(\frac{\bar{\beta}}{\sigma_{\beta}^2} + \frac{\hat{\beta}}{\text{se}^2} \right) \right] + \text{const}$$

- ▶ Completing the square: a Normal posterior with variance $v = (1/\sigma_{\beta}^2 + 1/\text{se}^2)^{-1}$
 - ▶ and mean $v(\bar{\beta}/\sigma_{\beta}^2 + \hat{\beta}/\text{se}^2) = w\hat{\beta} + (1-w)\bar{\beta}$, with $w = \sigma_{\beta}^2/(\sigma_{\beta}^2 + \text{se}^2)$
2. Law of total variance: $\text{Var}(\hat{\beta}) = \text{Var}(\mathbb{E}[\hat{\beta} \mid \beta]) + \mathbb{E}[\text{Var}(\hat{\beta} \mid \beta)] = \sigma_{\beta}^2 + \mathbb{E}[\text{se}^2]$
- ▶ Empirical Bayes: $\hat{\sigma}_{\beta}^2 = \max\{\text{Var}_{cs}(\hat{\beta}) - \overline{\text{se}^2}, 0\}$
 - ▶ Using $\text{Var}_{cs}(\hat{\beta})$ itself counts sampling noise as true dispersion and shrinks too little

A3 [Solved]: Solution (2/2) — Numbers and Forecasts



3. $\hat{\sigma}_\beta^2 = 0.1159 - 0.0077 = 0.1082$; $\text{se}^2 = 0.0193$;
 $w = 0.849$; $\beta^V = 0.849 \times 1.415 + 0.151 \times 0.949 = 1.344$;
 posterior variance 0.0164 (s.d. 0.128); Blume 1.278
4. Errors against 1.172: raw 0.243, Vasicek 0.172, Blume 0.106

- XNK's beta is precise, so Vasicek shrinks it little; Blume moves every beta one third of the way to 1
- The later beta is itself an estimate; A4 (extension) asks why regression to the mean exceeds sampling noise

A5 [Solved]: Ten Candidate Factors — Task

- ▣ **Question:** how many of ten new factors are discoveries once we account for testing ten at a time?
- ▣ **Inputs:** a new example (not the lecture's vector); level $\alpha = 5\%$, $M = 10$ two-sided tests of zero mean
- ▣ **Tasks:** complete the worksheet
 1. Count the naive discoveries $p \leq 0.05$ and the Bonferroni discoveries $p \leq 0.005$.
 2. Holm: compare $p_{(j)}$ with $0.05/(M - j + 1)$ and stop at the first failure.
 3. Benjamini–Hochberg: find the largest j with $p_{(j)} \leq 0.005j$ and reject $H_{(1)}, \dots, H_{(j)}$.
 4. State which error rate each procedure controls and under which dependence; extension: Benjamini–Yekutieli.

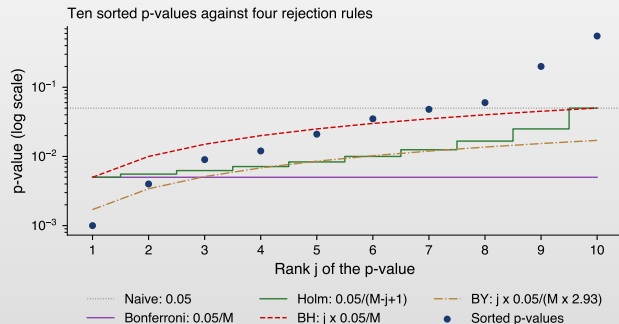
j	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
$p_{(j)}$	0.001	0.004	0.009	0.012	0.021	0.035	0.048	0.060	0.20	0.55
Holm $0.05/(M - j + 1)$	0.0050	...								
BH $0.005j$	0.005	...								

- ▣ **Report:** the completed worksheet and the four counts; Notebook: section A5

A5 [Solved]: Solution

j	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
$p_{(j)}$	0.001	0.004	0.009	0.012	0.021	0.035	0.048	0.060	0.20	0.55
Holm	0.0050	0.0056	0.0063	0.0071	0.0083	0.0100	0.0125	0.0167	0.025	0.05
BH	0.005	0.010	0.015	0.020	0.025	0.030	0.035	0.040	0.045	0.050

- Naive 7; Bonferroni 2
- Holm: $0.009 > 0.0063$ is the first failure: 2
- BH: $p_{(5)} = 0.021 \leq 0.025$ is the largest pass ($p_{(6)} = 0.035 > 0.030$): 5
- Bonferroni, Holm: FWER, any dependence; BH: FDR, independence or positive dependence; BY (thresholds /2.93): FDR, any dependence, 1 discovery
- Interpretation: a factor search tolerates a known share of false factors, so FDR is the relevant target



B1 [Solved]: Beta and Alpha of XLK — Task

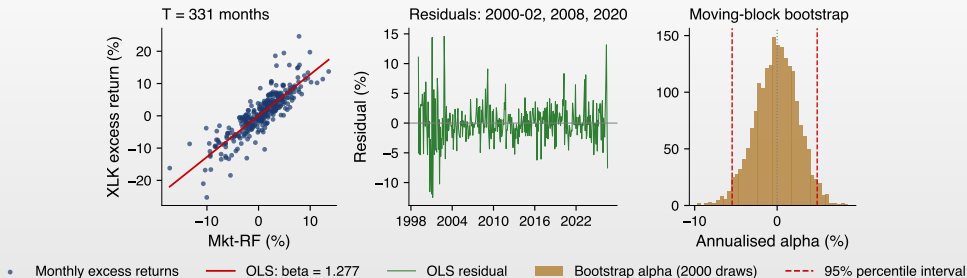
- ▣ **Question:** what are the CAPM beta and alpha of the technology ETF, and how precisely are they known?
- ▣ **Data:** XLK and Mkt-RF, monthly excess returns January 1999 – July 2026 ($T = 331$), as in the Setup slide
- ▣ **Tasks**
 1. Estimate $R_{\text{XLK},t}^e = \alpha + \beta \text{Mkt-RF}_t + \varepsilon_t$ by OLS; annualise α and its standard errors by multiplying by 12.
 2. Compute classical, White (heteroskedasticity-robust) and Newey–West standard errors of α and β , with $L = 5$ lags.
 3. Test $H_0 : \alpha = 0$ at 5% with the Newey–West t -statistic.
 4. Moving-block bootstrap (Künsch (1989)): resample blocks of 12 consecutive months of the pairs (R_t^e, f_t) together, re-estimate α , 2000 draws, seed 42; report the 95% percentile interval.
 5. Plot the data with the fitted line, the residuals over time and the bootstrap distribution.
- ▣ **Report:** a table (estimate, three standard errors), $t(\alpha)$, R^2 , the interval and the chart
- ▣ **Interpretation:** the HAC error of beta is twice the classical one: which feature of the residuals causes it?
- ▣ Notebook: section B1

B1 [Solved]: Solution (1/2) — Step by Step

	Estimate	Classical s.e.	White s.e.	Newey–West s.e.
α (annualised)	0.33%	2.27%	2.32%	2.45%
β	1.277	0.041	0.054	0.082

1. $R^2 = 0.742$; monthly $\hat{\alpha} = 0.027\%$, so $12 \times 0.027\% = 0.33\%$ a year
2. Lags $L = \lfloor 4 \times 3.31^{2/9} \rfloor = \lfloor 5.2 \rfloor = 5$; robust 95% interval of β : $1.277 \pm 1.96 \times 0.082 = [1.12, 1.44]$ instead of $[1.20, 1.36]$
3. $t(\alpha) = 0.33/2.45 = 0.13$, $p = 0.89$: do not reject; no evidence of a CAPM alpha
4. Bootstrap: $\alpha \in [-5.5\%, 4.9\%]$, standard deviation of the draws 2.61%; the interval contains 0

B1 [Solved]: Solution (2/2) — Chart and Interpretation



- Classical errors assume $\text{Var}(\varepsilon_t | f_t)$ constant and no serial correlation; the sandwich weights each squared residual by $(f_t - \bar{f})^2$
- White raises the s.e. of β from 0.041 to 0.054: residuals are large when the market moves a lot (2000–2002, 2008, 2020); Newey–West raises it further to 0.082: the products $f_t \varepsilon_t$ are serially correlated
- The point estimates are the same; only the uncertainty changes

B2 [Solved]: GRS Test on Sector ETFs — Task

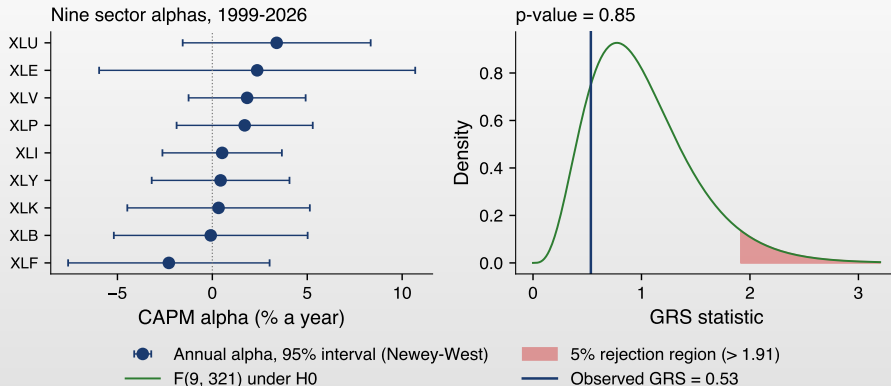
- ▣ **Question:** do the nine sector ETFs jointly reject the CAPM?
- ▣ **Data:** 9 sector ETFs, month-end adjusted prices joined on common months; monthly excess returns January 1999 – July 2026 ($T = 331$, $N = 9$); factor Mkt-RF
- ▣ **Tasks**
 1. Run the 9 time-series regressions on Mkt-RF; report the annual alphas with Newey–West intervals and the betas.
 2. Build the residual matrix $\hat{E}$ ($T \times 9$), $\hat{\Sigma} = \hat{E}^\top \hat{E} / T$ and the quadratic form $\hat{\alpha}^\top \hat{\Sigma}^{-1} \hat{\alpha}$ with monthly alphas.
 3. Compute $\hat{\mu}_m$, $\hat{\sigma}_m$ (ML), then $W = \frac{T-N-1}{N} \frac{\hat{\alpha}^\top \hat{\Sigma}^{-1} \hat{\alpha}}{1 + \hat{\mu}_m^2 / \hat{\sigma}_m^2}$ and its p -value from $F(9, 321)$.
 4. Repeat the test on the 25 size $\times$ B/M portfolios over the same 331 months.
- ▣ **Report:** the coefficient table, the three inputs of W , W , p , the chart and the same-period comparison
- ▣ **Interpretation:** the 25 portfolios reject the CAPM ($GRS = 4.20$ over 1963–2026); why are the sectors silent?
- ▣ **Model:** A1 (efficiency), B1 (regression); Notebook: section B2

B2 [Solved]: Solution (1/2) — From Residuals to W

	XLB	XLE	XLF	XLI	XLK	XLP	XLU	XLV	XLV
$\hat{\alpha}$ (% a year)	-0.1	2.4	-2.3	0.5	0.3	1.7	3.4	1.8	0.4
NW s.e. (% a year)	2.6	4.2	2.7	1.6	2.5	1.8	2.5	1.6	1.9
$\hat{\beta}$	1.05	0.92	1.07	1.05	1.28	0.45	0.40	0.67	1.07

1. No alpha is significant alone; the largest $|t|$ is XLU's $3.4/2.5 = 1.3$
 2. $\hat{E}$: 331×9 ; $\hat{\Sigma}$: 9×9 ; monthly alphas (%): $-0.007, 0.197, -0.191, 0.043, 0.027, 0.142, 0.282, 0.153, 0.036$;
 $\hat{\alpha}^\top \hat{\Sigma}^{-1} \hat{\alpha} = 0.0153$
 3. $\hat{\mu}_m = 0.659\%$, $\hat{\sigma}_m = 4.51\%$, $SR_m = 0.146$; $W = \frac{321}{9} \times \frac{0.0153}{1+0.146^2} = 35.67 \times 0.0150 = 0.53$, $p = 0.85$
 4. Same 331 months, 25 size $\times$ B/M portfolios: $GRS = 2.91$, $p = 9 \times 10^{-6}$
- ☐ Interpretation: the silence comes from the test assets, not from the sample; sectors mix small and big, value and growth
 - ☐ Not rejecting is not accepting the CAPM: choose test assets that spread the characteristics suspected to be priced

B2 [Solved]: Solution (2/2) — Chart and Interpretation



- $W = 0.53$ lies in the body of $F(9, 321)$, far below the 5% critical value 1.91: do not reject H_0 : all $\alpha_i = 0$
- Sharpe-ratio form (A2): the sectors raise the monthly Sharpe ratio only from 0.146 to 0.191 (annual $0.51 \rightarrow 0.66$)

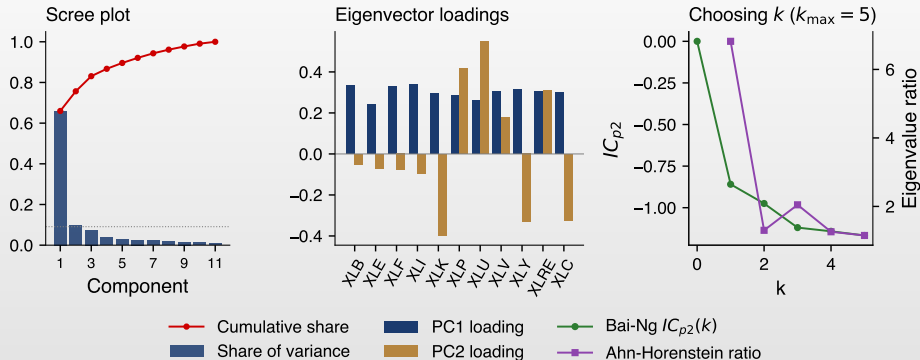
B3 [Solved]: PCA and the Number of Factors — Task

- ▣ **Question:** how many common factors drive the daily returns of the US sectors, and what are they?
- ▣ **Data:** 11 sector ETFs, daily log returns on common days, 20 June 2018 – 18 September 2026 ($T = 2073$); SPY held out for comparison
- ▣ **Tasks**
 1. Standardise each column: Z is $T \times 11$; compute $C = Z^\top Z / T$, its eigenvalues $\lambda_1 \geq \dots \geq \lambda_{11}$ and unit-length eigenvectors, signed so that their loadings sum to a positive number.
 2. Report the shares $\lambda_k/11$ of PC1–PC3 and the loadings of PC1 and PC2; build the scores $Z\gamma_1$ and correlate them with SPY.
 3. Number of factors, $k_{\max} = 5$: Kaiser ($\lambda_k > 1$); Bai–Ng, $\hat{k} = \arg \min_{0 \leq k \leq 5} [\ln V(k) + k \frac{N+T}{NT} \ln \min(N, T)]$ with $V(k) = \sum_{j>k} \lambda_j / N$; Ahn–Horenstein, $\hat{k} = \arg \max_{1 \leq k \leq 5} \lambda_k / \lambda_{k+1}$.
- ▣ **Report:** shares, loadings, the correlation with SPY, the three estimates of k and a chart
- ▣ **Interpretation:** PC2 opposes utilities and staples to technology: would it earn a premium? What would you need to test it?
- ▣ Notebook: section B3

B3 [Solved]: Solution (1/2) — Components

1. Eigenvalues 7.26, 1.06, 0.82, 0.40, 0.32, ... (they sum to 11)
2. Shares: PC1 66.0%, PC2 9.7%, PC3 7.4%; the first three explain 83.1%
 - ▶ PC1 loadings all positive (0.24–0.34): an almost equal-weighted portfolio; $\text{corr}(\text{PC1 scores}, \text{SPY}) = 0.954$: strongly market-related, not identical to SPY
 - ▶ PC2: XLU +0.55, XLP +0.42, XLRE +0.31 against XLK −0.40, XLY −0.33: defensive versus growth
3. The eigenvectors are portfolio weights on standardised returns, not betas; a return beta on PC1 needs a regression of each sector on the scores
 - The estimators of k disagree (next slide): with $N = 11$ the large- N asymptotics do not apply; report the range, not a single k
 - Interpretation: PCA explains covariance, not average returns; to test a PC2 premium run Fama–MacBeth with PC2 betas on many assets, or sort assets on PC2 loadings into a long–short portfolio and test its mean with Newey–West errors

B3 [Solved]: Solution (2/2) — How Many Factors?



- Kaiser: 2 (7.26 and 1.06 exceed 1); Bai-Ng: penalty $\frac{N+T}{NT} \ln 11 = 0.219$ per factor, IC_{p2} keeps falling (0, -0.86, -0.97, -1.12, -1.14, -1.17) and hits $k_{\max} = 5$
- Ahn-Horenstein: ratios 6.82, 1.30, 2.05, 1.26, 1.15, maximum at $k = 1$

C2 [Proposed]: Critique an AI Answer — the Answer

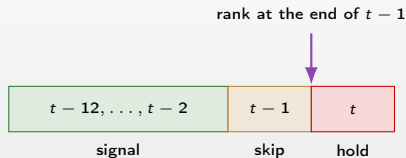
- **Prompt** sent to an AI assistant: “P holds cleaned month-end adjusted prices of 10 BVB blue chips, one column per stock. Build a 12-month momentum long–short portfolio, top 3 minus bottom 3 with equal weights, and report its annual mean and volatility”
- **Answer:** the code below and the conclusion

```
R      = np.log(P).diff()                # monthly returns
mom    = P.pct_change(12)                # past 12-month return
ls     = {}
for t in R.index[13:]:
    s = mom.loc[t].dropna().sort_values() # rank the stocks
    ls[t] = R.loc[t, s.index[-3:]].mean() - R.loc[t, s.index[:3]].mean()
ls = pd.Series(ls)
print(12 * ls.mean(), np.sqrt(12) * ls.std()) # annual mean, volatility
```

- **Conclusion of the AI:** “Momentum earns about 48% a year with a volatility of 16%. This agrees with [Fama & French \(2012\)](#), who document momentum on the Bucharest Stock Exchange.”

C2 [Proposed]: Critique an AI Answer — Task

- **Strategy intended by the student** (the contract): 12–1 momentum, i.e. the compounded return of months $t - 12, \dots, t - 2$, known at the end of month $t - 1$; eligible if the signal and the price at the end of $t - 1$ exist; long the top 3, short the bottom 3, equal weights, simple returns of month t
- **Data**: 10 blue chips (TLV, SNP, BRD, TGN, FP, SNG, SNN, EL, DIGI, TEL), month-end, December 2015 – August 2026; a month with $|r| > 0.5$ (FP, September 2023) is unavailable
- **Tasks**
 1. Audit the timing of the signal, the aggregation of returns across stocks and the citation; list every error you find.
 2. For each error, say how you would detect it: a test, a published number, the lecture or the paper itself.
 3. Write the corrected code and report the annual mean, volatility and number of months.
 4. Log each error in the format of `AI_ERRORS.md`: request, answer, error, how found, correction.
- **Interpretation**: does “about 48% a year” survive, and at which hurdle (1.96 or 3) is the corrected premium significant?



- The formation weights must not change if prices after the end of month $t - 1$ change
- AI code usually runs without an error message: the mistakes are in the finance, not in the syntax
- Model: B1 and the lecture (momentum, Section 5); Notebook: section C2

B4 [Proposed]: CAPM Betas of BVB Blue Chips — Task

- **Question:** how sensitive are the BVB blue chips to the BET index, and how do stale prices bias daily betas?
- **Data:** 11 blue chips (<SYMBOL>.R0) and BET; each stock joined separately with BET on common days; daily log returns from 6 January 2015 (or the listing date: DIGI May 2017, H2O July 2023) to 18 September 2026; a constant R_f cancels

□ Tasks

1. Form the lead and the lag of BET on the full calendar of each pair, then drop days with $|r_t| > 0.5$ for the stock or BET; report the dropped days.
 2. Estimate each beta by OLS on BET, with Newey–West errors (lag rule) and R^2 .
 3. Compute empirical-Bayes Vasicek betas (A3), the 11 stocks as the cross-section.
 4. Dimson betas (Dimson (1979)): regress $r_{i,t}$ on $r_{\text{BET},t-1}$, $r_{\text{BET},t}$, $r_{\text{BET},t+1}$ and sum the three slopes.
- **Report:** a table of the four betas and a chart with 95% intervals

Cleaning example: DIGI around 23 May 2017

Date	r_{DIGI}	BET_{t-1}	BET_t	BET_{t+1}	keep
19 May	1.78%	−0.31%	0.65%	0.22%	yes
22 May	2.73%	0.65%	0.22%	0.05%	yes
23 May	−658.7%	0.22%	0.05%	0.48%	no
24 May	−2.97%	0.05%	0.48%	0.48%	yes
25 May	1.74%	0.48%	0.48%	0.66%	yes

- The unadjusted corporate event creates a log return of −6.59; the day is dropped
- The lead and the lag of the kept days still use BET on 23 May: form them before dropping
- **Interpretation:** which stocks does the Dimson correction move most, and why?
- Model: B1, A3; Notebook: section B4

Submission Checklist and Team Repository

Hand in before the next seminar

- ▣ A1, A3, A5: the derivations and the worksheet
- ▣ B1, B2, B3: one table and one figure each, as in the solutions
- ▣ C2: corrected code, the table of results, your error log
- ▣ B4: the table and the chart of betas
- ▣ One interpretation sentence per exercise

Team repository

- ▣ One Quantlet folder: B1 for one asset of your project (beta, three standard errors, bootstrap interval, chart)
- ▣ Optional project starts: C1 (BVB factor premia) or C3 (US replication), not both
- ▣ Log AI use in AI_USE.md and caught errors in AI_ERRORS.md
- ▣ Extension packs are optional

Extension Packs: What Each One Needs

Pack	Exercises	Prerequisites
1. Pricing restrictions	A1 Extended [Solved], A2, A4	A1, A3, B2
2. Two-pass inference	A7 [Solved], A6, B5, B9, B11	B1, B2, lecture Section 6
3. Model comparison	B10	B1, lecture Section 7
4. Multiple testing on real alphas	B7	A5, B1
5. Latent factors	A8, B8	B3
6. Daily factor ETFs	B6	B1
7. BVB factor premia	C1	B4, C2
8. Replication project	C3	A3, A5, lecture case study

- Each pack has its own notebook section and starter code; do them in order within a pack
- Useful for the team project: C1 and C3 are possible project starts

A1 Extended [Solved]: Other Efficient Portfolios — Task

- ▣ **Question:** does the beta pricing equation need the market, or only an efficient benchmark?
- ▣ **Inputs:** as in A1; two benchmarks
 - ▶ a CML portfolio, aw_m in risky assets ($a > 0$) and $1 - a$ in the risk-free asset
 - ▶ a frontier portfolio of risky assets only (gross returns R , means m): the first-order condition of $\min w^\top \Sigma w$ s.t. $w^\top m = m^*$, $w^\top 1 = 1$ gives $\Sigma w = \kappa_1 m + \kappa_2 1$
- ▣ **Tasks**
 1. Show that the CML portfolio has $\beta_{i,p} = \beta_i/a$ and $\mu_p = a\mu_m$, so $\mu_i = \beta_{i,p}\mu_p$ again.
 2. From the first-order condition, show $m_i - \gamma = \beta_{i,p}(m_p - \gamma)$ with $\gamma = -\kappa_2/\kappa_1$, the zero-beta rate.
 3. State what this implies for a test of the CAPM with a market proxy.

A1 Extended [Solved]: Solution

1. The excess return of the CML portfolio is aR_m^e : $\text{Cov}(R_i^e, aR_m^e) = a \text{Cov}(R_i^e, R_m^e)$ and $\text{Var}(aR_m^e) = a^2 \sigma_m^2$, so $\beta_{i,p} = \beta_i / a$; with $\mu_p = a\mu_m$, $\beta_{i,p}\mu_p = \beta_i\mu_m = \mu_i$
2. $\text{Cov}(R, R_p) = \Sigma w = \kappa_1 m + \kappa_2 \mathbf{1}$ and $\sigma_p^2 = w^\top \Sigma w = \kappa_1 m_p + \kappa_2$
 - Hence $\kappa_1(m - \gamma \mathbf{1}) = \text{Cov}(R, R_p)$ and $\kappa_1(m_p - \gamma) = \sigma_p^2$; divide: $m - \gamma \mathbf{1} = \beta_p(m_p - \gamma)$
 - γ is the mean of every portfolio with zero beta on p : the zero-beta CAPM of [Black \(1972\)](#)
3. Any mean–variance efficient benchmark prices all assets exactly by beta; a rejection means that the proxy is not efficient for the test assets, which is a statement about the proxy as much as about the model (Roll's critique)

A2 [Proposed]: GRS Equals a Sharpe-Ratio Gain — Task

- ▣ **Question:** why does GRS measure how much the test assets improve the market's Sharpe ratio?
- ▣ **Notation:** $Y_t = (f_t, R_t^e)^\top$, $(N+1) \times 1$; ML moments $\mu_Y = (\mu_f, \mu_R^\top)^\top$ and $V = \begin{pmatrix} \sigma_f^2 & \sigma_{Rf}^\top \\ \sigma_{Rf} & \Sigma_R \end{pmatrix}$, all divided by T ;
 $\beta = \sigma_{Rf} / \sigma_f^2$, $\alpha = \mu_R - \beta \mu_f$, $\Sigma = \Sigma_R - \beta \beta^\top \sigma_f^2$
- ▣ **Supplied identity** (block inverse with the Schur complement Σ of σ_f^2)

$$V^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} 1/\sigma_f^2 + \beta^\top \Sigma^{-1} \beta & -\beta^\top \Sigma^{-1} \\ -\Sigma^{-1} \beta & \Sigma^{-1} \end{pmatrix}$$

▣ Tasks

1. Expand $SR^2(f, R) = \mu_Y^\top V^{-1} \mu_Y$ into four terms and show that it equals $\mu_f^2 / \sigma_f^2 + \alpha^\top \Sigma^{-1} \alpha$.
2. Write the GRS statistic W as a function of $SR^2(f)$ and $SR^2(f, R)$.
3. The 25 size $\times$ B/M portfolios: $T = 757$, $N = 25$, monthly $SR(f) = 0.134$, $SR(f, R) = 0.405$; compute W and decide at 5% (critical value of $F(25, 731)$: 1.52).
4. Compare the observed gain with the gain expected under H_0 , $N(1 + SR^2(f))/(T - N - 3)$.

- ▣ **Report:** the algebra, W , the decision and one sentence; Model: A1, B2

A4 [Proposed]: Blume's Slope as a Shrinkage Weight — Task

- **Question:** is the regression of later betas on earlier betas a Vasicek estimator?
- **Toy assumptions:** true betas constant, $\hat{\beta}_{i,k} = \beta_i + \eta_{i,k}$ in periods $k = 1, 2$; the noises are independent of β_i and of each other, with a **common** variance s^2 ; β_i has mean $\bar{\beta}$ and variance σ_β^2
- **Tasks**
 1. Derive, as $N \rightarrow \infty$, the limits of the OLS slope b and intercept a of $\hat{\beta}_2$ on $\hat{\beta}_1$.
 2. Show that $a + b\hat{\beta}_1$ is then the Vasicek beta with $w = b$.
 3. With A3's $\sigma_\beta^2 = 0.1082$, $s^2 = 0.0077$, $\bar{\beta} = 0.949$, compute the implied b and a ; compare them with the fitted 0.724 and 0.230 and plot both lines.
 4. The fitted slope has standard error 0.114: compute $(0.724 - b)/0.114$ as an illustration and list the explanations that remain possible.
- **Model:** A3

	$\hat{\beta}_1$ 1999–2012	se ₁	$\hat{\beta}_2$ 2013–2026
XLB	1.174	0.083	1.026
XLE	0.904	0.089	1.051
XLF	1.217	0.120	1.029
XLI	1.122	0.057	1.078
XLK	1.415	0.139	1.172
XLP	0.451	0.064	0.578
XLU	0.463	0.086	0.455
XLV	0.716	0.047	0.705
XLY	1.083	0.063	1.169

A7 [Solved]: Errors in Variables in Pass 2 — Task

- **Question:** how much does pass 2 attenuate a premium because the betas are estimated?
- **Setting:** one factor, $R_{it} = a_i + \beta_i f_t + \varepsilon_{it}$; ε_{it} i.i.d. over t and i , variance σ_ε^2 , independent of f and of the β_i ; the β_i i.i.d. across assets with variance $\text{Var}_{cs}(\beta)$
- **Three premia:** λ , the true price of risk; $\mu_f = \mathbb{E}[f_t]$; $\lambda_T = \lambda + \bar{f} - \mu_f$, the realised premium in the sample. Pricing restriction: $a_i = \lambda_0 + \beta_i(\lambda - \mu_f)$
- Work conditionally on the factor path $f_1, \dots, f_T$; pass 2: OLS of $\bar{R}_i$ on $(1, \hat{\beta}_i)$, $\hat{\beta}_i = \beta_i + \eta_i$, $\eta_i = \sum_t (f_t - \bar{f}) \varepsilon_{it} / \sum_t (f_t - \bar{f})^2$
- **Tasks**
 1. Show $\text{Var}(\eta_i | f) = \sigma_\varepsilon^2 / (T \hat{\sigma}_f^2)$ and $\text{Cov}(\eta_i, \bar{\varepsilon}_i | f) = 0$.
 2. Show that, for $N \rightarrow \infty$ and T fixed, the pass-2 slope converges to $\lambda_T \text{Var}_{cs}(\beta) / [\text{Var}_{cs}(\beta) + \sigma_\varepsilon^2 / (T \hat{\sigma}_f^2)]$.
 3. Compute the attenuation factor for the two panels below, with $\text{Var}_{cs}(\beta) = \text{Var}_{cs}(\hat{\beta}) - \bar{\sigma}_\varepsilon^2 / (T \hat{\sigma}_f^2)$, and explain what the Shanken correction fixes.

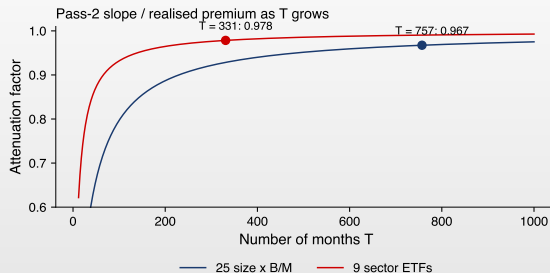
Panel (CAPM)	T	$\text{Var}_{cs}(\hat{\beta})$	$\bar{\sigma}_\varepsilon^2$ (% ² per month)	$\hat{\sigma}_f^2$ (% ² per month)
25 size $\times$ B/M, 1963–2026	757	0.01905	9.33	19.87
9 sector ETFs, 1999–2026	331	0.09247	13.45	20.36

A7 [Solved]: Solution (1/2) — Derivation

- Given f , η_i is a linear combination of the ε_{it} with weights $(f_t - \bar{f}) / \sum_s (f_s - \bar{f})^2$
 - ▶ $\text{Var}(\eta_i | f) = \sigma_\varepsilon^2 \sum_t (f_t - \bar{f})^2 / [\sum_s (f_s - \bar{f})^2]^2 = \sigma_\varepsilon^2 / (T \hat{\sigma}_f^2)$
 - ▶ $\text{Cov}(\bar{\varepsilon}_i, \eta_i | f) = \sigma_\varepsilon^2 \frac{1}{T} \sum_t (f_t - \bar{f}) / \sum_s (f_s - \bar{f})^2 = 0$, because $\sum_t (f_t - \bar{f}) = 0$
- With the restriction, $\bar{R}_i = \lambda_0 + \lambda_T \beta_i + \bar{\varepsilon}_i$: the realised factor mean $\bar{f}$ is common to all assets and does not average out as $N \rightarrow \infty$
 - ▶ Given f , $(\beta_i, \eta_i, \bar{\varepsilon}_i)$ are i.i.d. across i : $\widehat{\text{Cov}}_{cs}(\bar{R}, \hat{\beta}) \rightarrow \lambda_T \text{Var}_{cs}(\beta)$ and $\widehat{\text{Var}}_{cs}(\hat{\beta}) \rightarrow \text{Var}_{cs}(\beta) + \sigma_\varepsilon^2 / (T \hat{\sigma}_f^2)$
 - ▶ The ratio is the stated limit: attenuation of λ_T towards zero; $\lambda_T - \lambda = \bar{f} - \mu_f$ vanishes only as $T \rightarrow \infty$

A7 [Solved]: Solution (2/2) — Numbers

3. 25 portfolios: noise $9.33 / (757 \times 19.87) = 0.00062$;
 $\text{Var}_{cs}(\beta) = 0.01905 - 0.00062 = 0.01843$; factor
 $0.01843 / 0.01905 = 0.967$
 9 sectors: noise $13.45 / (331 \times 20.36) = 0.00200$;
 $\text{Var}_{cs}(\beta) = 0.09048$; factor 0.978
- The bias is only 2–3% here: diversified portfolios have small residual variance and T is long; single stocks have a much larger σ_ε^2 , so the attenuation grows
- **Shanken (1992)** corrects the standard error of $\hat{\lambda}$ for the noise in $\hat{\beta}$ (a variance correction); it does not remove the finite- T bias of the point estimate



A6 [Proposed]: A Useless Factor in Pass 2 — Task

- ▣ **Question:** why can a factor unrelated to returns look priced in pass 2?
- ▣ **Assumptions:** N fixed, $T \rightarrow \infty$; R_t i.i.d. over time with means μ_i , nonsingular covariance Σ , finite fourth moments; a factor g_t , i.i.d., mean 0, variance σ_g^2 , independent of all returns, so $\beta_{i,g} = 0$; in the proof g is the only factor in pass 2
- ▣ **Tasks**
 1. Show that $\sqrt{T} \hat{\beta}_{i,g} \rightarrow N(0, \sigma_i^2 / \sigma_g^2)$: $\hat{\beta}_{i,g}$ is of order $T^{-1/2}$ (numerator and denominator separately).
 2. Write $\hat{\lambda}_g = \widehat{\text{Cov}}_{cs}(\bar{R}_i, \hat{\beta}_{i,g}) / \widehat{\text{Var}}_{cs}(\hat{\beta}_{i,g})$ with $z = \sqrt{T} \hat{\beta}_g$; show $\hat{\lambda}_g$ is of order $\sqrt{T}$ when the μ_i differ.
 3. Case of equal means: using the joint limit of $(\sqrt{T}(\bar{R} - \mu), z)$, show that $\hat{\lambda}_g$ converges to a non-degenerate random variable, not 0.
 4. The lecture simulation adds g to the CAPM on the 25 portfolios (2000 replications): explain its rejection rates and which first-pass test protects against them.
- ▣ **Model:** A7; **Notebook:** section A6

B5 [Proposed]: Fama–MacBeth on ETFs — Task

- ▣ **Question:** are the market, size and value premia priced in 16 US ETFs over 2013–2026?
- ▣ **Data:** 9 sector ETFs and 7 factor ETFs (MTUM, VLU, QUAL, USMV, IWM, IWD, IWF), monthly excess returns August 2013 – July 2026 ($T = 156$): a 156×16 panel; factors Mkt-RF, SMB (three-factor file), HML: 156×3
- ▣ **Tasks**
 1. Pass 1: full-sample regressions of each ETF on the three factors; report $\hat{B}$ (16×3).
 2. Pass 2: for each month, OLS of the 16 returns on $X = [1, \hat{B}]$; show one month in full (fitted against actual), then average the 156 slopes; annualise by 12.
 3. Standard errors: Fama–MacBeth, Newey–West on $\hat{\lambda}_t$ (6 lags), Shanken ($\text{Var}_{\text{sh}} = (1 + c)(\text{Var}_{FM} - \Sigma_f / T) + \Sigma_f / T$, no factor term for the intercept); extension: Kan–Robotti–Shanken from the notebook helper `two_pass_gmm`.
 4. Compare each $\hat{\lambda}$ with the time-series mean of its factor in a chart and test $\lambda = 0$ at 5%.
- ▣ **Interpretation:** is a non-significant premium here evidence that size and value are not priced?
- ▣ **Model:** B1, B2 and lecture Section 6; Notebook: section B5

B9 [Proposed]: A Lewellen–Nagel–Shanken Check — Task

- **Question:** does FF3's high cross-sectional R^2 survive broader test assets and a GLS metric (Lewellen, Nagel & Shanken (2010))?
- **Data:** 25 size $\times$ B/M and 30 industry portfolios (Kenneth French Data Library), monthly excess returns July 1963 – July 2026 ($T = 757$); FF3 factors
- **Definitions:** μ : mean excess returns ($N \times 1$); $X = [1, \hat{B}]$; $\hat{V}$: sample covariance of returns
 - ▶ OLS fit $e = \mu - X\hat{\gamma}$, $R_{OLS}^2 = 1 - e^\top e / \sum_i (\mu_i - \bar{\mu})^2$
 - ▶ GLS: $\hat{\gamma}_{GLS} = (X^\top \hat{V}^{-1} X)^{-1} X^\top \hat{V}^{-1} \mu$; $R_{GLS}^2 = 1 - e_G^\top \hat{V}^{-1} e_G / (\mu - \bar{\mu}_G 1)^\top \hat{V}^{-1} (\mu - \bar{\mu}_G 1)$, with $\bar{\mu}_G = 1^\top \hat{V}^{-1} \mu / 1^\top \hat{V}^{-1} 1$
- **Tasks**
 1. Baseline: FF3 on the 25 portfolios; plot actual against fitted means; report both R^2 .
 2. Add the 30 industries and repeat; also impose $\lambda = \mathbb{E}[f]$ with no intercept and report R_{OLS}^2 with the same denominator.
 3. Uncertainty: resample months i.i.d. (500 draws), re-estimate both passes and $\hat{V}$ in each draw; report 95% intervals.
 4. Extension: CAPM and FF5 on both sets of assets.
- **Interpretation:** does the FF3 R^2 survive once industries are added? Model: B2, lecture Section 6

B11 [Proposed]: GRS without Normality — Task

- **Question:** is the rejection of the CAPM on the 25 portfolios an artefact of assuming Normal residuals?
- **Data:** 25 size $\times$ B/M portfolios, CAPM with Mkt-RF, monthly July 1963 – July 2026 ($T = 757$, $N = 25$)
- **Tasks**
 1. Diagnostics: estimate the 25 regressions; compute the Pearson kurtosis $\frac{1}{T} \sum_t \hat{\epsilon}_t^4 / \hat{\sigma}^4$ of each residual (3 under the Normal distribution) and the average; draw a Q–Q plot.
 2. Exact test: GRS with the ML $\hat{\Sigma}$ and its p -value from $F(25, 731)$.
 3. Null bootstrap: resample whole rows of residuals (keeping their cross-correlation), rebuild $R_t^* = \hat{\beta} f_t + \epsilon_t^*$ (so $\alpha = 0$), refit and recompute GRS 2000 times; $p = (1 + \#\{W^* \geq W\})/2001$ and the 95% bootstrap critical value.
 4. Extension, robust Wald: moments $\epsilon_t \otimes (1, f_t)$, parameters ordered (α, β) ; $W = \hat{\alpha}^\top \hat{V}_\alpha^{-1} \hat{\alpha} \rightarrow \chi_{25}^2$ with the sandwich $D^{-1} \hat{S} D^{-1} / T$, $D = (Z^\top Z / T) \otimes I_{25}$, $Z = [1, f]$, and $\hat{S}$ White or Newey–West (6 lags).
 5. Explain why GRS cannot be computed for the 100 size $\times$ B/M portfolios over August 2018 – July 2026 ($T = 96$).
- **Model:** B2; **Notebook:** section B11

B10 [Proposed]: Comparing Models by Sharpe Ratios — Task

- **Question:** which factor model spans the highest Sharpe ratio, and is the difference significant ([Barillas & Shanken \(2018\)](#))?
- **Data:** monthly Mkt-RF, SMB, HML, RMW, CMA, MOM ([Kenneth French Data Library](#)), July 1963 – July 2026 ($T = 757$) and January 2000 – July 2026 ($T = 319$)
- **Membership:** CAPM (Mkt-RF); FF3 and Carhart use the three-factor SMB; FF5 and FF5 + MOM the five-factor SMB; covariances with $T - 1$
- **Tasks**
 1. Compute $SR^2 = \mu_f^\top \Sigma_f^{-1} \mu_f$ for each model, annualise ($\times 12$) and report $\sqrt{SR^2}$.
 2. Nested comparison, FF5 + MOM against FF5: regress MOM on the five FF5 factors and test the intercept (spanning regression, Newey–West).
 3. Non-nested comparison, FF5 against Carhart: stationary bootstrap ([Politis & Romano \(1994\)](#)), mean block 6 months, 2000 draws with the same indices for both models; 95% interval of the SR^2 difference.
 4. Extension: spanning t of each of the six factors on the other five, in both periods.
- **Interpretation:** why can the percentile interval of a nested difference never contain 0? Which factors add no significant alpha after 2000?
- **Model:** B1; **Notebook:** section B10

B7 [Proposed]: Multiple Testing of 25 Alphas — Task

- ▣ **Question:** how many of the 25 size $\times$ B/M portfolios have a genuine FF3 alpha?
- ▣ **Data:** 25 value-weighted size $\times$ B/M portfolios (25_Portfolios_5x5) and the FF3 factors (Fama & French (1993)), monthly excess returns July 1963 – July 2026 ($T = 757$)
- ▣ **Tasks**
 1. For one portfolio (small-growth), show the full path: FF3 regression, Newey–West t of α (6 lags), two-sided $p = 2(1 - \Phi(|t|))$.
 2. Repeat for all 25; draw a 5×5 heatmap of the annual alphas with their t .
 3. Sort the p -values and apply the A5 worksheet: naive, Bonferroni, Holm, Benjamini–Hochberg; extension: Benjamini–Yekutieli.
 4. Count the portfolios with $|t| > 3$ (Harvey, Liu & Zhu (2016)), a heuristic hurdle, not a procedure with a guaranteed error rate.
- ▣ **Interpretation:** the 25 tests are strongly correlated: which methods remain valid, and which test uses the correlation directly?
- ▣ **Model:** A5; **Notebook:** section B7

A8 [Proposed]: Equicorrelated Assets — Task

▣ **Question:** how does the share of the first component depend on the average correlation and on N ?

▣ **Stage 1,** $N = 3$, $\rho = 0.5$: $C = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0.5 & 0.5 \\ 0.5 & 1 & 0.5 \\ 0.5 & 0.5 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$

1. Verify that $\mathbf{v}_1 = (1, 1, 1)/\sqrt{3}$, $\mathbf{v}_2 = (1, -1, 0)/\sqrt{2}$, $\mathbf{v}_3 = (1, 1, -2)/\sqrt{6}$ are orthonormal eigenvectors and find the eigenvalues.
2. Compute the PC1 share $\lambda_1/3$.

▣ **Stage 2,** N assets, $C = (1 - \rho)I + \rho \mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^\top$

3. Show $\lambda_1 = 1 + (N - 1)\rho$ and all other eigenvalues $1 - \rho$; find the limit of the PC1 share as $N \rightarrow \infty$.
4. Invert the share formula to get the equicorrelation-equivalent ρ of a PC1 share s ; apply it to the BVB blue chips ($N = 10$, $s = 0.425$, B8) and the US sectors ($N = 11$, $s = 0.660$, B3).
5. Extension: for a general C with average off-diagonal correlation $\bar{\rho}$, show $1 + (N - 1)\bar{\rho} \leq \lambda_1$.

▣ Model: B3; Notebook: section A8

B8 [Proposed]: PCA of BVB Blue Chips — Task

- ▣ **Question:** is the first factor of the Romanian blue chips as strong as in the US sectors?
- ▣ **Data:** 10 blue chips (TLV, SNP, BRD, TGN, FP, SNG, SNN, EL, DIGI, TEL; H2O excluded, listed in 2023) and BET, joined on common days from 7 June 2017 to 18 September 2026; daily log returns; drop days with any $|r_t| > 0.5$ and report how many; BET is held out of the PCA
- ▣ **Tasks**
 1. Apply the B3 recipe: standardise ($T \times 10$), eigenvalues, variance shares, PC1 loadings.
 2. Correlate the PC1 scores with the BET returns.
 3. Number of factors: Kaiser, Bai–Ng and Ahn–Horenstein with $k_{\max} = 5$.
 4. Compare with the US sectors on the same period (from 20 June 2018): PC1 shares and scree plots side by side.
- ▣ **Interpretation:** what does a weaker first factor imply for diversification within the BVB, and how much of the gap comes from comparing stocks with sector portfolios?
- ▣ **Model:** B3; **Notebook:** section B8

B6 [Proposed]: Do Factor ETFs Have Alpha? — Task

- **Question:** do MTUM and QUAL earn an alpha beyond their six-factor exposures?
- **Data:** adjusted prices of MTUM (18 Apr 2013 – 31 Jul 2026) and QUAL (18 Jul 2013 – 31 Jul 2026); daily FF5 (Fama & French (2015)), MOM (Carhart (1997)) and RF, same end date
- **Calendar rule:** keep an ETF return only if the previous ETF price is on the previous factor trading day
 - ▶ Example: MTUM has prices on 18 and 23 April 2013 but none on 19 and 22 April; the return 18 → 23 April covers three factor days and is dropped
- **Tasks**
 1. Build daily excess returns with the calendar rule; report n before and after alignment.
 2. Estimate $R_t^e = \alpha + b \text{MKT}_t + s \text{SMB}_t + h \text{HML}_t + r \text{RMW}_t + c \text{CMA}_t + m \text{MOM}_t + \varepsilon_t$; annualise α by 252.
 3. Newey–West standard error (10 lags) and t of α ; moving-block bootstrap of the pairs, blocks of 20 days, 1000 draws: 95% interval.
 4. Plot the two intervals for each ETF.
- **Interpretation:** why must a 3-day ETF return never be regressed on a 1-day factor return? Model: B1

C1 [Proposed]: Do Factor Premia Exist on the BVB? — Setting

- **Question:** do momentum (Jegadeesh & Titman (1993)) and low beta earn premia among BVB blue chips?
- **Data:** month-end adjusted prices of the 10 blue chips of C2 and BET, December 2015 – August 2026 (September 2026 incomplete); monthly simple returns; a month with $|r| > 0.5$ (FP, September 2023) is unavailable for signals and holding returns
- **Rules fixed in advance**
 - ▶ signal and beta use information up to the end of $t - 1$ (timeline of C2)
 - ▶ at least 6 eligible stocks; ties broken by ticker order
 - ▶ a missing holding return is dropped from the leg mean

Ranking for August 2026

Stock	Signal	Leg
EL	129.9%	long
TGN	127.3%	long
DIGI	113.2%	long
SNG	88.9%	
BRD	87.8%	
SNN	75.5%	
TEL	66.1%	
FP	51.0%	short
TLV	48.5%	short
SNP	46.6%	short

Signal: compounded return of August 2025 – June 2026, known at the end of July 2026

C1 [Proposed]: Do Factor Premia Exist on the BVB? — Tasks

▣ Tasks

1. Momentum 12–1 (C2 contract): long the top 3, short the bottom 3, equal weights.
2. Low beta: 36-month rolling betas on BET (at least 18 months, ending at $t - 1$); long the 3 lowest, short the 3 highest; an unscaled spread, not the beta-neutral BAB of [Frazzini & Pedersen \(2014\)](#).
3. Report periods, T , annual mean, volatility and Newey–West t (3 lags); compare t with 1.96 and 3; plot the cumulative spreads.
4. Discuss survivorship (today's blue chips chosen with hindsight), short-selling constraints, costs and liquidity.
5. Extension: public sources of book equity and shares outstanding for a BVB value factor.

▣ **Deliverable:** a Quantlet folder in the team repository and one slide with the conclusion and its main limitation

▣ **Model:** B4, C2; Notebook: Part C

C3 [Proposed]: Do US Factors Replicate? A Staged Project (1/2)

- **Context:** the lecture case study, [Jensen, Kelly & Pedersen \(2023\)](#): 82.4% of US factors keep a significant CAPM alpha under a hierarchical empirical-Bayes model, against 75.6% with Benjamini–Yekutieli and 35% in [Hou, Xue & Zhang \(2020\)](#) (Figure 1)
- **Data manifest:** value-weighted univariate sorts of the [Kenneth French Data Library](#), July 1963 – July 2026, and Mkt-RF from the three-factor file; long–short extremes on 15 characteristics
 - ▶ extreme 30%: size, book-to-market, operating profitability, investment, earnings/price, cash flow/price, dividend/price, accruals, net share issues; extreme 20%: market beta, variance, residual variance; extreme 10%: prior returns 12–2, 1–0 and 60–13 months
- **Stage 1, construction and frequentist rates**
 1. Build the 15 factors, long the side that earned more in the original paper; cite that paper for each sign.
 2. Regress each factor on Mkt-RF, rescale it to a monthly residual volatility of $10\%/\sqrt{12}$ (Section II.A of the paper), report $\hat{\alpha}$, t and the OLS replication rate ($t \geq 1.96$).
 3. Apply Benjamini–Yekutieli at 5% and report the critical t and the rate.

C3 [Proposed]: Do US Factors Replicate? A Staged Project (2/2)

□ Stage 2, themes and the hierarchical model

4. Ward dendrogram on the distance 1 – correlation of the CAPM residuals; compare with the paper's themes (Cluster Labels.csv, [authors' code](#)).
5. $M (15 \times J)$: theme membership; estimate τ_c, τ_w by maximum likelihood of $\hat{\alpha} \sim N(0, MM^T \tau_c^2 + I \tau_w^2 + \hat{\Sigma}/T)$, report a boundary estimate $\tau_c = 0$ if it occurs; posterior means and variances (Proposition 4), the empirical-Bayes rate (posterior $z \geq 1.96$).

□ Stage 3, sensitivity: the rate with a single theme and as a function of τ_c ; the Bayesian FDR (Proposition 5)

□ Stage 4, post-sample decay: alphas within the original sample years (from July 1963) and after them, at least 60 months in each; feasible GLS of post-sample on in-sample alphas with the inverse factor covariance; compare the slope with 0.26 (Figure 8)

□ Report: a factor table (alpha, t , theme, posterior mean, z), the rates next to Figure 1, $\hat{\tau}$ next to Table I, the dendrogram and the slope; keep the paper's numbers and the course numbers apart

□ Model: A3, A5 and the lecture case study

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